

The University of British Columbia
Department of Economics

Economics 560: Economics of Labour

Professor Nicole M. Fortin
Tuesday, Thursday: 14:00-15:30

Fall 2013
Buchanan B218

Guidelines for your Referee's Report

In the course of this class, you will be asked to write two (2) referee reports on assigned papers that are at the “working paper” stage. As you pursue a career as a professional economist, writing referee reports will become part of your usual duties. As a student, it will give you the opportunity to study a paper in great detail, develop critical thinking skills, and learn about the fine craft of economic writing. Your referee reports should be 3-4 pages long and should include at the end a recommendation to the editor (that normally goes in the cover letter) as to whether the paper should be (1) accepted for publication as it stands, (2) accepted, subject to minor revisions, (3) returned to the author for major revisions, a judgement on publication to be made after resubmission, or (4) rejected. Let's assume that the paper has been directed at a high level field journal such as the *Journal of Labor Economics* or the *Journal of Human Resources* of which I am a co-editor.

A referee report normally begins with a short summary of the objectives of the paper, and of what the authors have accomplished in the paper. The key questions that you want to answer in this part of the report are: What did the authors view themselves as doing and what did they accomplish? This part should generally be no more than one half-page to one page long, given the editor has also read the paper. It should be quite neutral in tone as if you were recording the information for yourself. Your summary of the paper is a way of establishing your credibility to the authors and the editor, who want to know that you have carefully studied their paper and that you have understood the key points made by the paper and the nature of the contribution to knowledge. You are also providing the authors, and the editors, with an alternative introduction to and a summary of their work.

At this stage, you may also want to place the paper in the literature and may wish to indicate which parts (theoretical development, empirical results, methodology, policy implications) make a (i) very important contribution, or (ii) fairly important contribution or (iii) a not very important contribution to the literature. Note that it is the authors' responsibility to establish the fact that an important contribution has been made. You may want to peruse a key paper that the authors cite as a source of debate or that provides the motivation for their paper. You may also wish to make a brief comment on the expositional qualities of the paper; that is, is the paper straightforward to read and self-contained, or is the exposition convoluted. You shouldn't hesitate to make positive comments, if warranted, even if your judgement is ultimately going to be harsh.

The second part of the report, the critical analysis, is the most important one and should be 2 -3 pages long. In this part you discuss the merits of the paper itself and whether the paper does make a contribution to knowledge that is worthy of publication in this prestigious journal. You may want to organize your discussion by going from the big picture to the smaller details.

- 1) Overall view: The most important question to answer here is: Did the paper accomplish what it set out to do? Did the authors take the best approach, and were they successful in their approach? You may also want to evaluate the importance and originality of the question. Many papers are correct in their internal logic and fill some gap in the literature, but do not make an important advance in knowledge.
- 2) Main concerns: If there are some critical problems with the manuscript in that the authors' analysis is incorrect in some manner then it is important to state these problems clearly in your evaluation. Here is a list of potential problems, luckily only a few might be present in the paper that you are evaluating. It could be that a) the description of the related literature is inappropriate to the actual material in the paper; b) the logical argument is not tight, including incorrect application of economic concepts or erroneous mathematical derivations; c) the econometric tools are being used inappropriately; d) there is only a loose link between the economic model and the empirical analysis; e) the coefficients of interest are not properly identified or not shown to be robust enough; f) the interpretation of empirical results is inappropriate given the available data and econometric strategy used or goes beyond what has actually been proven, g) the conclusions are incorrectly made or expressed; and h) the contribution to the literature is inaccurately described. You can also comment on the structure and organization of the paper and make suggestions as to whether the reader might be better served by alternative ways of presenting and discussing the theory and/or empirical results. Avoid making suggestions that the authors have not hope to being able to follow. If you are suggesting a "revise and resubmit" (options 2 and 3 in the opening paragraph above), you should point out some possible solutions to the problems that you identify.
- 3) Smaller points These are concerns that are usually easily corrected, but that are important nevertheless. You may want to mention a) areas where the author's line of thought is hard to follow or confusing; b) important mathematical derivations that are obscure; c) spelling and grammatical errors; d) missing data sources and poorly constructed Tables or Figures; e) references to the literature that are missing or incorrect.